EG Japan Angle - English

送信者: EG Japan Research 受信日時: 2026-10-28 00:40

【メール原文】

Japan-Russia tensions continue to spike Putin’s first visit to the disputed Kuril Islands in August took Tokyo by surprise and signaled a potentially ||||||||||||||||

Japan Angle

Customize Email Preferences

Tokyo’s growing Russia problem

*
Japan-Russia tensions will remain high as Moscow strengthens its claim over the disputed Kuril Islands and increases other forms of military and diplomatic pressure against Tokyo.
*
Although Tokyo is trying to arrange a bilateral meeting between Prime Minister Takaichi Sanae and President Vladimir Putin at the APEC or G20 summits to ease tensions, Moscow is unlikely to agree to a meeting this year.
*
Takaichi prefers engagement over confrontation with Moscow, although her weak response to Moscow’s pressure could invite further escalation.

27 Oct 2026 11:39 EDT Discover more on the Portal
Short-term trajectory:
Long-term trajectory:

Japan-Russia tensions continue to spike

Putin’s first visit to the disputed Kuril Islands in August took Tokyo by surprise and signaled a potentially more lasting shift in Russia’s strategic posture toward Japan. The islands lie off Hokkaido’s northern tip and remain a highly sensitive political issue for Tokyo, which has sought their return since the end of WWII. Former prime minister Abe Shinzo cultivated close ties with Putin while in office—much to Washington’s dismay—largely in the hope of securing the islands’ return. But Putin’s visit there in August effectively foreclosed any possibility of Russia voluntarily returning the islands to Japan. The trip will also set back bilateral relations for the foreseeable future and further delay the conclusion of a formal peace treaty.

Russia has also increased military pressure on Japan. Moscow routinely sends surveillance ships near Japanese territorial waters and long-range aircraft through Japan’s air defense identification zone (ADIZ), forcing Tokyo to scramble fighter jets in response. But the pace of this activity has increased this year. Japan scrambled jets against Russian aircraft 152 times from April to September 2026, up from 59 in the same period in 2025. Russia has also conducted large-scale naval drills in waters surrounding Japan, including near the Kuril Islands, as well as frequent joint air and naval patrols with China. Additionally, Russia continues to expand and upgrade its military infrastructure, surveillance

networks, and missile deployments on and around the Kurils, which hold both strategic and political importance for Moscow—making their return to Japan highly unlikely.

Japan's annual defense white paper, released in early August, criticized Russia on several fronts. It highlighted frequent Russian aircraft incursions into Japan's ADIZ, joint China-Russia bomber flights and naval patrols near Japanese territory, Russian aggression against Ukraine, and increasing Russia-North Korea-China trilateral cooperation. One week after the white paper's release, Putin made his visit to the Kurils; one week later, Russia conducted military exercises around the disputed islands that included hypersonic missile test launches.

Russia has added pressure in other ways. It detained a Japanese journalist this month who was working on Sakhalin Island, which is located not far from the disputed islands. Moscow accused the journalist of espionage and denied him access to Japanese embassy officials. Japan dispatched a senior diplomat to Moscow to seek the journalist's release—a visit was granted after a lengthy delay—although a prisoner exchange appears unlikely in the near term, as Japan does not currently hold any high-profile Russian spies or other prisoners. The detained journalist will likely remain a bargaining chip for Moscow—and a political headache for Takaichi—for the foreseeable future.

Moscow's motivations remain murky

The reasons for Russia's increased coercion against Japan are unclear. Putin's visit to the Kuril Islands was initially seen as an effort to boost his domestic approval ahead of legislative elections in September. However, Moscow's coercion campaign has continued and broadened in scope since the election, suggesting that other factors may also be at play.

Russia is likely aligning more closely with China and North Korea, both of which harbor historical and contemporary grievances against Japan. In particular, Moscow is backing Beijing's effort to isolate Takaichi in the hope of weakening her domestic political standing. Russia has largely endorsed China's rhetorical condemnation of Japan, both for its wartime actions and for the threat posed by Japanese "re-militarization" under the right-wing Takaichi (see: Beijing will maintain calibrated pressure campaign against Tokyo , 20 July 2026). By applying pressure on Japan's northern frontier, Russia is also indirectly aiding China by drawing Japanese attention and resources away from the western region, where the Self-Defense Forces are focused on deterring Chinese aggression.

In September, Russia unveiled a large bronze statue in Khabarovsk—located near the Chinese border—depicting a Russian soldier smashing a border marking bearing the Japanese imperial symbol. Earlier this month, officials and business leaders from northeast China visited the Kuril Islands, signaling support for Russian sovereignty over the disputed territory and reversing China's earlier verbal support for Japan's claims.

Moscow's anger at Tokyo also appears motivated by Japan's continued support for Ukraine. Japan remains one of Ukraine's largest non-Western supporters and has provided more than $16 billion in financial and humanitarian aid to Kyiv since 2022. Tokyo and Kyiv are also expanding cooperation on drone technology. In September, Takaichi met with President Volodymyr Zelensky for the first time on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly. Earlier this month, Japan also announced new sanctions against Russia over the war in Ukraine.

Japan's response has been weak

Tokyo has largely remained quiet amid Russia's escalating pressure, owing to disagreements over the best response. One camp of Japanese officials wishes to take a harder line toward Moscow—viewing

Russia as an increasingly rogue state—while the other camp advocates for greater engagement, citing Japan's deep economic links with Russia and the remoteness of the Ukraine conflict from East Asia.

Takaichi, meanwhile, lacks strong convictions about policy toward Russia. She called Putin's visit "unacceptable" at the time but did not take any further action. Japan's ambassador to Russia, who comes from the pro-engagement camp of the foreign ministry, remains at his post in Moscow.

Takaichi's restraint is consistent with her response to China's coercion against Japan since November 2025. Tokyo continues to seek dialogue with Beijing rather than retaliate against China's rare earths restrictions. Tokyo continues to fear that retaliation will only invite further escalation from Moscow—or Beijing—with no guarantee of US support given Washington's dovish turn toward Russia and China under President Donald Trump.

Japan-Russia tensions will persist

Moscow, like Beijing, has also shown little interest in mending ties with Tokyo. In May, Russia downplayed the significance of a visit to Moscow of senior officials from the Ministry of Economy, Trade, and Industry and the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. The delegation was seeking to protect the interests of dozens of Japanese companies that continue to operate in the country. Japan also remains heavily reliant on LNG imports from the Sakhalin-II project, whose strategic value for Japan has risen since the outbreak of conflict in the Middle East.

Takaichi is hoping for a diplomatic breakthrough with Putin at the APEC or G20 summits. Her meeting with Zelensky last month was a necessary precursor to a summit with Putin, though Moscow appears unlikely to agree to a meeting with her this year.

Takaichi's restraint also risks inviting further escalation from Moscow. Putin was likely surprised, if not emboldened, by Tokyo's muted reaction to his visit to the Kuril Islands. Russia will therefore probably maintain its assertive posture toward Japan until Tokyo adopts a tougher response or Moscow wins additional concessions.

However, there are limits to how far Russia's pressure campaign is likely to go. Moscow does not want to cause the exit of the Japanese companies that remain in Russia, or to push Tokyo to align more closely with Kyiv. Russia benefits from maintaining a line of communication with the more sympathetic elements of Japan's foreign policy establishment, even as it seeks to isolate Takaichi.

Jeremy Chan
Senior Analyst, China & Northeast Asia
chan@eurasiagroup.net
EG Japan Research
japanresearch@eurasiagroup.net

© 2026 Eurasia Group. All rights reserved. This material was produced by Eurasia Group for use by the recipient. This is intended as general background research and is not intended to constitute advice on any particular commercial investment or trade matter or issue and should not be relied upon for such purposes. It is not to be made available to any person other than the recipient. No part of this publication may be reproduced, stored in a retrieval system, or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or otherwise, without the prior consent of Eurasia Group.
X-HG-DocID cmvq3b4im0xeg07n1lkq4cidq

Opt Out | Customize Email Preferences